

Stone tools from Kenya about 2.3 mi llion year old



An Olduvai chopper

Subsistence necessities of prehistoric humans were mainly food and water.

The human ancestors perhaps did not possess complex language skills as we have now. They might have voiced a few sounds or words and possibly used sign language. They were intelligent enough to select stones as **raw material** and used the **hammer stones** to carefully flake the rocks and design tools for their needs. They hunted animals, fed on the meat of the animals killed by predators and gathered plant foods such as roots, nuts and fruits. In India, the Acheulian tools have been found near Chennai and many other sites such as Isampur in Karnataka and Bhimbetka in Madhya Pradesh.

Raw material is the naturally available stone block or pebbles selected by humans for making tools. Since these stones produced flakes with sharp edges, they were selected for making stone tools.

Core is the main block of stone from which small chips are flaked by using a hammer stone.

Flake is a small chip removed from a large stone block called the core.

Middle Paleolithic Culture

After about 3,98,000 years Ago, further changes took place in the **lithic technology** in Africa. The *Homo erectus* species existed during this period. Anatomically modern humans are said to have emerged around 3 lakh years ago.

Lithic Technology: 'Lith' means stone. The methods and techniques involved in the production of stone tools are called Lithic technology.

The hand axes turned out to be much attractive in design and many smaller tools were also produced. The core was prepared and then tools were made. Points and scrapers were used. Short blades were also produced. The lithic tool-making tradition of the **Levalloisian** belonged to this period. The tools made during this time are found in Europe and Central and western Asia.

Levalloisian tools are the implements made aft er preparing the core. It was named aft er the town of Levallois in France.

The Middle Paleolithic Culture appeared between 3,85,000 and 1,98,000 years ago in Europe and parts of western and South Asia. The tools that were made during this period were in use till about 28,000.

The people of this period were called Neanderthals. They buried the dead people systematically.

Upper Paleolithic Culture

The cultural phase that succeeded the Middle Paleolithic is called the Upper Paleolithic phase. This period was marked by innovation in tool technology. Long blades and burins were produced during this time. People used different varieties of silica- rich raw materials in this phase. Numerous paintings and art objects were made. The diversity of artefacts suggests the improvement in cognitive skills and the development of languages. Microliths appeared in this phase.

Burin is a stone-made chisel with a sharp cutting edge.

The modern humans, who first appeared as a result of human evolution in the sub-Saharan Africa 300,000 years ago, began to move to various parts of Asia around 60,000

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